



The political violence as a social phenomenon

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Abstract

This research proposes a critical reassessment of the theory of unequal exchange by bringing the debate back to the Law of Value in political economy, rather than to market prices or wages. She argues that what appears to be an unequal exchange does not constitute a violation of the Law of Value, but rather results from distortions historically produced in the monetary expression of value, rooted in colonial extraction and the global circulation of precious metals. The study adopts a theoretical-critical methodology. She distinguishes between value, exchange value and price; introduces hypothetical numerical illustrations of the formation of value; and criticizes contemporary empirical studies that attempt to measure unequal exchange. The central argument is that the equality of exchange, with regard to the Law of Value, must be understood in terms of the necessary social expenditure of energy, which varies between advanced and underdeveloped countries

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1. Introduction

Political violence is a complex phenomenon that affects the stability of states and the cohesion of societies. It manifests in the use of force or the threat of force by individuals, groups, or even the state to achieve specific political objectives. The forms of political violence vary, including state-led repression of opponents, armed conflicts between political groups, or protests that escalate into violent confrontations, making this phenomenon a critical subject for academic study.

The importance of studying political violence lies in its role as an indicator of legitimacy and political crises within the state, as well as its direct impact on economic and social development and institutional stability, understanding its causes and consequences helps in designing effective strategies to mitigate it, enhance political participation, and build trust between the state and society, thereby contributing to a more peaceful and stable community.

This study aims to define the concept of political violence, its characteristics, and forms; analyze the social, political, and economic causes of political violence; examine its impact on political stability and socio-economic development; and review the possible mechanisms and strategies to reduce political violence and promote a culture of peace.

The central research question of this study is: What are the impacts of political violence on stability and development within society?, This question is further broken down into sub-questions concerning the relationship between poverty and social deprivation and the resort to violence, the role of the state and institutions in exacerbating or mitigating violence, and the

effects of political violence on sustainable development.

Chapter One: Conceptual and Theoretical Framework:

Political violence is a complex social phenomenon that arises from multiple interactions between individuals, groups, and the state, this chapter aims to study the concept of political violence, its characteristics, forms, and the distinctions between it and other types of violence.

The analysis starts from the hypothesis that political violence is not merely random acts of aggression, but an organized means through which actors seek to achieve specific political objectives, political sociology focuses on understanding political violence in the context of the relations between the state and society and its role as a mechanism for expressing social conflicts, whether they are class-based, ethnic, or ideological.

This chapter also reviews different theories that explain political violence, including the theory of relative deprivation, structural theory, conflict theory, and psychological theory, in order to provide a comprehensive view of the factors influencing its emergence and persistence.

Section One: The Concept of Political Violence:

The concept of political violence is a fundamental notion in political sociology due to its close connection with the relationship between power and society, as well as the nature of political conflict within the state, this concept cannot be fully understood in isolation from the social and political context in which it occurs.

1- Definition of Political Violence :

Political violence is defined as the use of physical force or the threat thereof by an individual, group, or the state itself, with the aim of achieving specific political objectives, such as influencing the structure of power, changing the existing political system, imposing a particular ideological orientation, or resisting public policies deemed illegitimate or unjust. In this context, political violence is understood as a means of political conflict, rather than merely an isolated act of aggression detached from its social environment.

Ted Robert Gurr defines political violence as “any violent act directed against the political system or its symbols, aimed at producing political change”, this definition highlights the direct connection between political violence and issues of political legitimacy, as well as the tense relationship between the state and society (Gurr, 1970, p. 24).

Johan Galtung offers a broader perspective, situating political violence within the framework of direct violence and viewing it as one form of visible violence used to achieve political goals amid deep structural and social imbalances, accordingly, political violence is not limited to physical acts alone but reflects accumulated social and political crises (Galtung, 1969, p. 171).

The definition of political violence rests on two essential elements:

-First Element is Violence :

This refers to the use of physical or symbolic coercion, whether through weapons, repression, threats, or intimidation, Violence does not necessarily have to be actual; the mere threat of force can suffice to achieve the intended political impact (Tilly, 2003, p. 15).

-Second Element is Political Objective :

This is the core element distinguishing political violence from other forms of violence, Political violence is aimed at influencing power, political decisions, or the governing system, criminal violence, for example, seeks personal gain, whereas political violence seeks collective goals with a political or ideological character (Heywood, 2019, p. 308).

Therefore, political violence can be regarded as a complex socio-political phenomenon that goes beyond individual acts , it reflects structural conflicts within society and disruptions in channels for political participation and peaceful expression.

2- Characteristics of Political Violence :

Political violence is distinguished by several characteristics that differentiate it from other forms of social or criminal violence, as it is closely linked to the political structure and the nature of conflict within society, understanding this phenomenon requires analyzing its essential features:

- Purposeful Nature :

Political violence is deliberate and goal-oriented, not random. Perpetrators use it to achieve clear political objectives, such as pressuring authorities, changing public policies, or undermining the legitimacy of an existing political system, Charles Tilly notes that political violence is employed as a strategic tool within political conflict, carefully chosen to produce specific political effects (Tilly, 2003, p. 18).

- Collective Nature:

Political violence is often carried out collectively, whether by political organizations, social movements, opposition groups, or even the state itself through official agencies, Ted Robert Gurr emphasizes that the collective nature of political violence reflects shared grievances and a collective sense of

deprivation or exclusion, Thus, political violence goes beyond individual action to become an expression of organized collective conflict (Gurr, 1970, p. 36).

- Symbolic Nature:

Political violence is not limited to causing direct physical harm; it also carries a significant symbolic dimension, used to convey political messages to authorities or the public, David Apter argues that political violence functions as a symbolic discourse, aiming to draw attention and assert presence in the public sphere when peaceful means of expression fail, therefore, the impact of political violence is measured not only by its physical scale but also by its psychological and political influence (Apter, 1997, p. 42).

- Connection to Political Conflict:

Political violence typically occurs within the context of struggles over power, resources, or political legitimacy, serving as an indicator of tension between the state and society, Andrew Heywood notes that political violence often arises when channels for political participation are blocked and democratic mechanisms are weak, prompting some actors to resort to force instead of dialogue (Heywood, 2019, p. 311).

These characteristics demonstrate that political violence is not arbitrary behavior but an organized socio-political phenomenon reflecting deep systemic imbalances, therefore , analyzing the features of political violence provides a crucial framework for understanding its causes and consequences within society.

3- Forms of Political Violence :

Political violence takes multiple forms that vary depending on the political actors, social context, and nature of the existing political system, it is not a fixed pattern but a dynamic

phenomenon that adapts to the conditions and levels of political conflict.

-State Violence :

State violence refers to the use of political authority to apply material or symbolic coercion against individuals or groups, aiming to maintain the existing political system or enforce obedience and compliance, this includes political repression, arbitrary arrests, excessive use of force, and restriction of public freedoms, Max Weber (1978, p. 54) asserts that the state monopolizes “legitimate violence”, but this monopoly can transform into political violence when used outside the framework of legality and established norms (Weber, 1978, p. 54), and Johan Galtung emphasizes that state violence often provokes counter-violence, escalating political conflict rather than containing it (Galtung, 1969, p. 173).

- Political Group Violence :

This form involves violence carried out by organized political groups, such as armed movements or extremist organizations, to achieve political or ideological objectives, these groups often resort to violence when peaceful means are ineffective or blocked, Ted Robert Gurr notes that this type of violence is associated with collective feelings of relative deprivation and political exclusion (Gurr, 1970, p. 47).

- Revolutionary Violence :

Revolutionary violence aims at radical change in the existing political and social system and is often directed against state institutions and symbols, Charles Tilly considers revolutionary violence a form of organized collective action, typically emerging during periods of acute legitimacy crises and state weakness, for some actors, this type of violence is justified as a

means to achieve justice or political liberation (Tilly, 2003, p. 26).

- Protest Violence :

Protest violence is linked to social movements and popular demonstrations, which usually begin peacefully but can escalate into confrontations due to security repression, lack of dialogue channels, or rising tensions between protesters and authorities, David Apter asserts that protest violence reflects a crisis in political communication, where the system fails to accommodate the demands of protesting groups within institutional frameworks (Apter, 1997, p. 58).

These diverse forms demonstrate that political violence is not exclusive to a single actor; it can originate from the state, opposition groups, or take revolutionary or protest-oriented forms, this diversity reflects the complexity of the phenomenon and its close connection to the nature of political conflict and the level of legitimacy within society.

4- Distinguishing Political Violence from Other Forms of Violence :

Distinguishing political violence from other forms of violence is essential for understanding the nature of this phenomenon and analyzing it scientifically, confusing different types of violence can lead to an oversimplified understanding of social and political phenomena, the fundamental differences lie in the motivations, objectives, and contexts in which the violence occurs.

-Conceptual Differences Between Political and Criminal Violence:

Political violence differs from criminal violence in terms of its primary objective, criminal violence aims to achieve personal or material gain, such as theft or individual revenge, and is primarily self-motivated. In contrast, political violence is associated with

collective objectives of a political nature, such as influencing authority, changing public policies, or undermining the legitimacy of the political system, Andrew Heywood emphasizes that political violence occurs within the framework of organized political conflict, whereas criminal violence remains outside this framework, even if it is occasionally organized (Heywood, 2019, p. 309).

Charles Tilly also notes that criminal violence lacks the symbolic and political dimension that characterizes political violence, as it does not aim to send political messages or influence public opinion (Tilly, 2003, p. 14).

-Conceptual Differences Between Political and Social Violence :

Social violence usually arises from social, familial, or cultural disputes, such as family conflicts or local community violence, and is often limited in scope without targeting political authority or state institutions, Johan Galtung argues that this type of violence reflects social or cultural tensions but does not reach the level of political violence unless it is directly connected to struggles over power or political legitimacy (Galtung, 1969, p. 170).

In contrast, political violence is closely linked to the political structure of society, as it is used as a tool for political pressure or as an alternative means to peaceful political participation when institutional channels are blocked (Gurr, 1970, p. 52).

This distinction demonstrates that political violence differs fundamentally from criminal and social violence in terms of motivations, objectives, and context, it is not merely an expression of personal or limited social conflict but reflects a broader political struggle associated with power, legitimacy, and decision-making, making it a central phenomenon in political sociology.

Moreover, it is evident that political violence is not simply deviant individual behavior but a complex socio-political phenomenon linked to the structure of society and the nature of the political system, understanding the concept of political violence is a crucial step toward analyzing its causes and effects in subsequent chapters of the study.

Section Two: Political Violence in Political Sociology:

Political violence occupies a central position in political sociology, as it reflects the nature of the relationship between the state and society, as well as the patterns of political and social conflict within the social structure, political sociology does not view political violence merely as deviant individual behavior; rather, it considers it the outcome of specific social, political, and economic conditions.

1- Political Sociology's Approach to Political Violence :

Political sociology approaches the analysis of political violence from the fundamental assumption that violence is neither random nor accidental; rather, it results from accumulated structural imbalances within the political and social system. It is viewed as a form of collective action that reflects tensions between the state and society, as well as struggles over power, resources, or political legitimacy.

Charles Tilly argues that political violence emerges when institutional channels fail to manage political conflict peacefully, that is, when formal institutions are unable to mediate between the interests of different actors, prompting some groups to resort to force as an alternative means to achieve their objectives (Tilly, 2003, p. 7), Tilly emphasizes that such collective action is not random; it is organized and strategic, reflecting the dynamics of power and conflict within society.

Ted Robert Gurr adds that political violence is often associated with the concept of "relative deprivation", which refers to the gap between what individuals or groups expect from the state and what they actually receive, this sense of deprivation is a key motivator for turning to violence as a tool of political pressure, especially when peaceful channels of participation are closed (Gurr, 1970, p. 24).

From the perspective of political sociology, political violence is not merely a set of individual actions; it represents a structural crisis within society and the state, where economic, social, and cultural factors interact with political frameworks to create a fertile environment for its emergence and persistence, therefore, studying political violence requires an integrated analysis encompassing political structures, social relationships, and cultural symbols that either justify or constrain the use of violence.

2- Political Violence and Its Relationship with the State and Society :

Political sociology emphasizes political violence as an indicator of the nature of the relationship between the state and society, viewing it as a signal of legitimacy crises or breakdowns in trust between rulers and the ruled, conditions leading to political violence often relate to a perception among groups or individuals that the state fails to meet their needs, or that political institutions do not provide legitimate channels for expressing their demands.

Max Weber asserts that the state is characterized by its monopoly on "legitimate violence", a fundamental aspect of its authority, however, this monopoly becomes questionable when coercion is used instead of organization, meaning that the instrument of law and order transforms into a tool for repressive control over society, thereby creating a fertile environment for counter-

violence by political actors and opposition groups (Weber, 1978, p. 56).

Moreover, Ted Robert Gurr emphasizes that political violence is often linked to “relative deprivation”, the gap between what individuals or groups expect from the state and what they actually receive, this sense of deprivation leads to the use of violence as a means of political pressure when legitimate channels of participation are weak or closed, providing a key explanation for the emergence of violent conflicts in multi-class and multi-group societies (Gurr, 1970, p. 24).

Thus, political violence reflects a disruption in the relationship between the state and society. It indicates the level of political legitimacy, the quality of laws and institutions, and the state's capacity to achieve justice and meet citizens' demands, from this perspective, understanding political violence requires analyzing power dynamics, inequalities in resource distribution, and institutional capacity to manage conflicts peacefully.

3- Political Violence as an Expression of Social Conflict :

Political sociology views political violence as an expression of deeper social conflicts that go beyond the immediate actors to include the broader social, political, and cultural structure. Political violence rarely occurs in a vacuum; rather, it results from overlapping imbalances in power distribution, economic inequality, social or ethnic discrimination, and ideological tensions.

Ralf Dahrendorf emphasizes that conflict is an inherent feature of modern societies, and political violence emerges when formal institutions fail to contain or manage conflict peacefully, in other words, when institutions are unable to mediate between different actors or manage societal disputes, some individuals or groups resort to violence as a means to

achieve their demands or defend their interests (Dahrendorf, 1959, p. 211).

From this perspective, political violence is understood not merely as a result of direct actions by individuals or groups, but as a product of a social structure that allows it to emerge and persist. Social factors such as class, ethnic affiliation, and economic disparities play a role in determining which groups are most likely to engage in or be subjected to violence, weak political institutions and a lack of democratic participation further facilitate the escalation of violence and its transformation into a tool for expressing social and political demands.

In connection with previous sections, political violence can be seen as a link between individual and collective actors and the broader political and social structure, it is not merely a circumstantial phenomenon, but an indicator of tensions between the state and society, imbalances between authority and societal participation, and discrepancies between social and political rights and responsibilities.

4- The Structural and Cultural Dimension of Political Violence :

Political sociology highlights the importance of structural and cultural factors in explaining political violence, viewing it as a phenomenon that does not arise independently of its social and political context, according to Johan Galtung, political violence is not limited to direct acts of aggression but also includes latent or structural violence—social and political arrangements that produce injustice and inequality, preventing social groups from accessing resources or participating equally in political life (Galtung, 1969, p. 171).

This perspective underscores that an unjust social structure, such as economic disparities, ethnic or sectarian discrimination, and political

exclusion, provides fertile ground for tensions to escalate into direct political violence, moreover, political culture plays a role in legitimizing or justifying violence through symbols, beliefs, or values that sanction the use of force to achieve political objectives, which helps explain the recurrence of violence in certain societies compared to others.

From this viewpoint, political violence results from the interaction between individual and collective factors and structural and cultural frameworks, rather than being a random or isolated act, this analysis complements previous discussions in the chapter, linking political violence to the state-society relationship, deep social conflicts, and imbalances in political legitimacy, therefore, studying political violence requires an integrated analysis of political structures, social composition, and political culture to understand how violence emerges, persists, and escalates.

Political sociology treats political violence as a complex, multidimensional phenomenon shaped by the interaction of structural, cultural, and social factors with both collective and individual actors within the context of the state-society relationship. Political violence is not merely a series of random acts of aggression but an indicator of crises in legitimacy, justice, and resource distribution, reflecting the interplay of social and political conflicts at multiple levels.

Section Three: Theories Explaining Political Violence:

Theories explaining political violence are essential tools for understanding the causes of the phenomenon and its development, they provide analytical frameworks linking individual and collective behavior with social and political structures, these theories vary across economic, psychological, social, and

political perspectives, allowing for a multidimensional understanding of political violence.

1- Economic Theory or Relative Deprivation :

The economic theory, also known as the theory of relative deprivation, focuses on the gap between what individuals or groups expect and what they actually obtain—whether economically, socially, or politically. This theory posits that feelings of deprivation are not solely based on absolute living standards, but also on comparisons with others or with personal or collective expectations.

Ted Robert Gurr argues that this sense of relative deprivation is a primary motivator for political violence, driving individuals and groups to use force to achieve their demands, particularly when legitimate channels for political or economic participation are closed, ineffective, or limited (Gurr, 1970, p. 24), from this perspective, political violence serves as a means of expressing social and political frustration and attempting to correct the inequalities and disparities experienced by individuals or groups.

This theory is one of the most explanatory frameworks for conflicts involving marginalized or excluded groups, it demonstrates how social and economic disparities can escalate into political violence as a tool of pressure or resistance. Moreover, it highlights the role of both individual and collective frustration in motivating actors to resort to organized forms of violence, the theory also provides insight into recurring patterns of political conflict in societies with significant economic and political inequalities and emphasizes that addressing political violence requires tackling the underlying causes of deprivation and social or political discrimination rather than merely focusing on the behavioral outcomes of violence.

2- Structural Theory :

Structural or institutional theory emphasizes the role of social and political structures in generating political violence. From this perspective, violence is not merely an individual act but the product of institutional social and political conditions. This theory suggests that imbalances in the distribution of power and resources, as well as unequal access to opportunities, create fertile ground for escalating tensions, thereby increasing the likelihood of political violence as a means to express demands or pressure authorities.

Johan Galtung, in his concept of structural violence, asserts that social injustice and inequality provide fertile conditions for latent violence to transform into direct political violence, especially in societies lacking institutional justice or equal political participation (Galtung, 1969, p. 171), here, structural violence is not limited to direct attacks but also includes systematic deprivation of individuals or groups from rights, resources, and political opportunities, making political conflict a persistent possibility.

The structural theory helps explain why manifestations of political violence recur in some societies more than others. Such phenomena reflect deep structural imbalances, including class disparities, ethnic or sectarian divisions, or centralized control over political and economic resources. From this perspective, addressing political violence requires comprehensive structural reforms, including the redistribution of resources, promotion of justice, and expansion of political participation, rather than relying solely on security or punitive measures.

3- Social or Conflict Theory :

Social theory, particularly conflict theory, emphasizes that political violence is an integral

part of modern societal dynamics, especially in the context of struggles over power and resources. According to this theory, heterogeneous societies—whether in terms of class, ethnicity, or ideology—contain ongoing tensions that can escalate into political and violent conflicts when appropriate institutional mechanisms are absent.

Ralf Dahrendorf argues that social conflict is inherent in modern societies, and that political violence emerges when institutions fail to manage or organize this conflict peacefully—when political participation channels or social dialogue mechanisms are ineffective or limited (Dahrendorf, 1959, p. 211), political violence, therefore, is not a random individual act but a collective mechanism for resolving disputes, often in societies lacking democratic institutions capable of mediating competing interests.

Conflict theory also explains the relationship between social and political structures and the escalation of violence, highlighting political violence as a tool for achieving collective interests in the absence of justice or equitable distribution of power and resources, institutional reform, expanded political participation, and enhanced social dialogue are essential strategies for reducing political violence according to this perspective.

4- Psychological or Individual Theory :

Psychological theory focuses on the individual psychological and behavioral factors driving political violence, such as frustration, collective anger, feelings of deprivation, or affiliation with extremist groups, this theory posits that political violence is not merely a social phenomenon but also a result of individual psychological processes influenced by surrounding social and political conditions.

David Apter notes that political violence can serve as a means of expressing feelings of

helplessness or political exclusion, reflecting an individual's desire to exert influence on authority or society, especially when peaceful methods of change or political participation are unavailable or ineffective (Apter, 1997, p. 42), from this perspective, violent acts are not only legal violations but also expressions of unmet psychological and political needs, such as recognition, power, or social justice.

Psychological theory helps explain why individuals become violent actors within organized groups, even though the root causes of violence are embedded in a broader social and political context. It complements structural and conflict theories by highlighting the individual dimension in collective dynamics of political violence.

These theories collectively demonstrate that political violence is a multidimensional phenomenon that cannot be explained by a single factor, economic, social, political, and psychological factors interact to create an environment conducive to the emergence and persistence of political violence, addressing this phenomenon requires comprehensive solutions, including structural reform, social justice, and enabling peaceful channels for political participation.

This chapter concludes that political violence reflects social structures, political relationships, and cultural norms, it is distinct from criminal or purely social violence due to its purposeful, collective, symbolic nature and its link to struggles over power or resources, theories discussed in this chapter highlight that political violence is not merely an individual behavior but a reflection of deep structural imbalances in society and the state, including economic, political, and social disparities. This lays the foundation for understanding its causes, consequences, and methods of prevention in subsequent chapters, offering a comprehensive academic and

practical perspective on addressing political violence.

Chapter Two: Causes of Political Violence:

Chapter two focuses on the causes and consequences of political violence, considering it as the result of the interaction of multiple social, political, and economic factors, this chapter aims to analyze the conditions that facilitate violence, such as class disparities, ethnic and religious divisions, state failure, struggles over power, repressive policies, economic deprivation, and lack of opportunities, in order to understand the motivations behind resorting to violence as a means of political and social expression.

The chapter also examines the consequences of political violence on political stability and socio-economic development, including the weakening of institutions, increased polarization, loss of legitimacy, decline in investment, destruction of infrastructure, and the impact on human capital.

This analysis provides a foundation for understanding the effective mechanisms to reduce political violence, which will be addressed in Chapter Three.

Section One: Social Causes of Political Violence:

Social causes represent a fundamental factor in explaining political violence, this type of violence often arises as a result of complex social interactions involving class structure, economic inequality, ethnic or religious divisions, and cultural conflicts, these causes are particularly pronounced in societies that lack effective mechanisms to manage conflicts or distribute resources fairly.

1- Class and Social Inequalities :

Class and social inequalities are among the most prominent causes of political violence, the

sense of marginalization or exclusion felt by disadvantaged groups often leads to heightened tensions and conflicts within society, this concept is closely linked to the theory of relative deprivation, which asserts that the perception of a gap between what individuals or groups expect and what they actually receive serves as a primary motivator for resorting to political violence (Gurr, 1970, p. 24).

Moore and Wilkinson note that social and economic disparities between classes create a conducive environment for escalating conflicts, especially when lower social groups perceive that the political and economic system fails to provide fair opportunities for participation or advancing their interests, this aligns with the analysis by Marx and Engels on class conflict, which emphasizes that the concentration of wealth and power in the hands of a few is a primary source of social and political struggles, leading to collective frustration and prompting marginalized groups to resort to violence to claim their rights (Marx & Engels, 1970, p. 48).

Thus, class and social inequalities are not merely economic factors; they are social and political determinants that influence the dynamics of conflict and create fertile ground for violent struggles when peaceful channels for participation and equality are absent.

2- Ethnic and Religious Divisions :

Ethnic and religious divisions play a significant role in the outbreak of political violence, particularly in multi-ethnic or multi-religious societies that experience institutional or social discrimination, the absence of justice and equality between groups often leads to persistent struggles over power and economic or political resources, which can easily escalate into direct political violence.

This observation is reinforced by social conflict theory, which sees intergroup conflicts as an inherent part of societal dynamics, and considers political violence to emerge when institutions fail to manage these conflicts peacefully (Dahrendorf, 1959, p. 211), the concept of ethnic or sectarian conflict also highlights that systematic discrimination based on ethnic or religious identity generates a sense of deprivation and grievance, increasing the likelihood of resorting to political violence to claim rights or protection (Horowitz, 1985, p. 35).

Cederman, Weidmann, and Gleditsch further argue that ethnic and religious divisions, particularly in weak states or in contexts of unequal resource distribution, heighten the risk of armed conflicts, including organized political violence, demonstrating the link between political and social structures and collective identities in fueling disputes (Cederman, Weidmann, & Gleditsch, 2011, p. 480).

Hence, ethnic and religious divisions are not merely cultural or social factors; they are complex drivers interacting with political and institutional structures, underscoring the need for comprehensive policies promoting equality and preventing discrimination to mitigate political violence.

3- Social and Cultural Change :

Rapid social and cultural changes can also be a significant cause of political violence, especially when shifts in values, norms, or the spread of new cultural influences clash with traditional structures of society or the state, this relates to the cultural dimension of political violence, where beliefs and values may legitimize or justify the use of violence to achieve political objectives.

Structural and cultural theories suggest that political violence does not occur in a vacuum;

it emerges in a social and cultural context that legitimizes or allows its occurrence, such as institutional injustice or unequal distribution of resources and opportunities (Galtung, 1969, p. 171) accordingly, cultural and social changes can reshape political conflicts, particularly when new values conflict with traditional structures or state policies.

It is evident that the social causes of political violence are multiple, including class disparities, ethnic and religious divisions, and social and cultural changes, these causes interact with political and institutional factors, creating a fertile environment for the escalation of violence, thus, studying political violence from a social perspective is essential to understand its roots and develop effective strategies for prevention.

Section 2: Political Causes of Political Violence:

Political causes are fundamental in explaining political violence, as such violence often emerges as a consequence of state failure, poor conflict management, or power struggles between different groups. Political analysis suggests that political violence is not a random event but is associated with institutional and structural factors that determine the distribution of power and the exercise of governance.

1- State Failure and Weak Institutions :

State failure and weak institutions are among the most prominent causes of political violence, the loss of the state's capacity to enforce law and ensure justice, or the lack of transparency and accountability within political institutions, creates fertile ground for protests and armed conflicts, when official institutions are unable to resolve disputes peacefully or distribute resources fairly, individuals and groups experience frustration, leading them to resort to violence as a means

of expressing demands or pressuring decision-makers (Tilly, 2003, p. 7).

This analysis aligns with Weber's concept of the state monopoly on legitimate violence (Weber, 1978, p. 56), ideally the state retains the right to use force to protect the social and political order, however when this monopoly is used to repress citizens or marginalize specific groups, official violence becomes a conflict-generating factor, and violent actions by society or opposition groups become a reaction to the lost legitimacy of institutions.

Furthermore, state failure can erode trust between citizens and institutions, making legal and legitimate channels for change ineffective, Moore and Wilkinson note that this disconnect between the state and society fosters an environment conducive to political violence, as groups resort to extra-legal mechanisms to reclaim rights or protect their interests (Moore & Wilkinson 2010, p. 112).

Analytically, this demonstrates that political violence is not merely an individual or random act but a cumulative result of weak institutions and their failure to manage conflicts, protect rights, and distribute power fairly, linking political violence directly to state structures and behavior toward citizens.

2- Struggles for Power and Sovereignty :

Struggles for power and sovereignty constitute a core cause of political violence, particularly in societies experiencing disputes over legitimacy or the distribution of influence among different groups, political analysis shows that competition over political positions and resources among factions or groups can escalate conflicts, especially when institutions are unable to manage disputes effectively or ensure fairness and equality in political representation (Dahrendorf, 1959, p. 211).

This phenomenon aligns with social conflict theory, which posits that political violence often serves as a means to restore balance or achieve the demands of marginalized groups, particularly in contexts lacking effective institutional channels for political participation or social dialogue (Tilly, 2003, p. 7).

Recent studies also indicate that the absence of political legitimacy or chronic corruption within institutions amplifies the perception among groups that legal channels for change are ineffective, driving them to resort to political violence as a strategy to influence power distribution or defend their interests (Moore & Wilkinson, 2010, p. 115).

Hence, struggles for power and sovereignty are not merely symbolic or political disputes; they are complex factors intertwined with state structures, institutions, and the nature of political legitimacy, showing how political systems themselves can incentivize violence when management and conflict resolution mechanisms fail.

3- Repressive Policies and Political Exclusion :

Repressive policies and political exclusion can ignite political violence, as marginalized groups increasingly feel injustice and frustration when denied political participation or fundamental rights. In such cases, violence becomes a means of expressing demands or pressuring authorities, especially if these groups perceive legitimate channels for change as closed or ineffective (Gurr, 1970, p. 24).

This phenomenon is consistent with the relative deprivation theory, which argues that the gap between the expectations of groups and the opportunities or rights they actually receive constitutes a primary motivation for resorting to violence (Moore & Wilkinson, 2010, p. 118), repressive policies not only generate individual and collective resentment but also

undermine the political legitimacy of the state, increasing the likelihood of escalation and spread of political violence among marginalized groups.

Tilly further emphasizes that political violence in contexts of exclusion is often organized and strategic, aiming to enforce change or resist state policies, this illustrates how formal authority itself can become a direct catalyst for violence when legitimate avenues for citizen and political actor participation are closed (Tilly, 2003, p. 7).

Thus, repressive policies and political exclusion are structural factors affecting power dynamics and control within the state, creating a continuous basis for political violence.

It becomes evident that political violence results from state failure, power struggles, and repressive policies, as these factors heighten the frustration of excluded groups and push them toward violence, therefore, mitigating political violence requires effective institutions, open channels for participation, and peaceful conflict resolution mechanisms.

Section 3: Economic Causes of Political Violence:

Economic causes are fundamental in explaining political violence, as armed conflicts or violent protests often emerge due to relative deprivation, poverty, and unequal distribution of resources, economic pressures generate frustration among marginalized groups, increasing the likelihood of using violence as a means to claim rights or achieve economic interests.

1- Relative Deprivation and Poverty :

Relative deprivation is one of the most prominent economic causes of political violence, it arises when individuals or groups perceive that economic resources or opportunities are unavailable to them

compared to others, this perceived gap between expectations and economic reality generates collective frustration and is considered a key factor motivating some groups to resort to violence to achieve economic, social, or political demands.

Gurr emphasizes that relative deprivation is a primary trigger for rebellion or armed protests, especially when legal and legitimate channels for political and economic participation are closed or ineffective, this analysis shows that the gap between what people expect from the state and what they actually receive can translate into collective armed conflict, particularly in societies with weak institutions and a lack of economic justice (Gurr, 1970, p. 24).

Moore and Wilkinson also note that relative deprivation is closely linked to economic and social inequality, and marginalized groups experiencing exclusion are in a fertile environment for political violence. Economic protests may escalate into organized violence if their structural causes are not addressed, this analysis highlights that relative deprivation is not merely an economic factor, but a multidimensional issue that intersects with politics and social structures (Wilkinson & Moore, 2010, p. 112), making it one of the most important economic explanations for political violence in modern societies.

2- Economic Inequality :

Economic inequality is another central factor contributing to political violence, especially in societies where power and wealth are concentrated in the hands of a few, concentration of resources and economic opportunities leads marginalized groups to feel excluded and unjustly treated, increasing the likelihood of resorting to violence as a means to protest or pressure authority (Moore & Wilkinson, 2010, p. 112).

The analysis indicates that political violence in the context of economic inequality is not simply a reaction to individual poverty but a cumulative outcome of institutional and structural discrimination that prevents marginalized groups from accessing resources and economic opportunities fairly, Collier and Hoeffler note that large gaps in income and wealth create fertile ground for armed conflicts, as excluded groups are more likely to transform their economic frustration into organized violence against the state or dominant groups (Collier & Hoeffler, 2004, p. 563).

Thus, economic justice and equitable distribution of resources are crucial for reducing the likelihood of political violence, helping alleviate tensions between different groups and opening peaceful channels to express economic and social demands.

3- Unemployment and Lack of Economic Opportunities :

Unemployment and lack of economic opportunities are critical economic factors in the escalation of political violence, young people and marginalized groups often feel that the system does not provide them with a stable future or fair opportunities to pursue their interests, this frustration creates a sense of exclusion and discrimination, making political violence a means to express economic and social demands.

Collier and Hoeffler point out that high levels of unemployment and poverty increase the likelihood of armed conflict, especially in states lacking effective social safety nets and institutional support, alongside relative deprivation and economic inequality, unemployment forms a fertile ground for turning economic frustration into organized political violence, as individuals and families perceive legal channels for change as

unavailable or ineffective (Collier & Hoeffler, 2004, p. 563).

Addressing unemployment, providing equitable economic opportunities, and enhancing social protection are therefore essential to reducing the risk of political violence and opening peaceful avenues for expressing economic and social demands.

It is evident that economic causes form a fundamental basis for the escalation of political violence. Relative deprivation, economic inequality, and unemployment collectively generate group frustration, driving individuals and communities to resort to violence to express their demands, these economic factors do not operate in isolation; they interact with social and political contexts, including state structures, institutional capacity, and availability of political participation channels.

Therefore, reducing political violence requires addressing poverty, promoting economic justice, providing equitable opportunities, and implementing institutional reforms that ensure conflicts are managed peacefully.

The second chapter demonstrates that political violence is not a transient phenomenon but reflects conflicts embedded in social, political, and economic structures, social factors, such as class disparities and ethnic or religious divisions, lay the groundwork for violent conflicts, while political factors, including weak institutions, power struggles, and repressive policies, escalate disputes, the analysis also highlights the negative impacts of political violence on political stability and economic and social development, through institutional weakening, disruption of democratic processes, decline in investment, and loss of human capital. These findings underscore the need for comprehensive strategies to mitigate political violence, including strengthening institutions,

addressing poverty and inequality, and fostering a culture of dialogue and tolerance, which will be explored in detail in Chapter Three.

Chapter Three: Effects of Political Violence and Strategies for Mitigation:

Chapter Three focuses on mechanisms to mitigate political violence, building on the analysis of its causes and consequences presented in the previous chapters, the chapter aims to review effective strategies for reducing political violence at both institutional and societal levels, including:

- Strengthening political and democratic institutions through enhanced legitimacy, transparency, and broader political participation.

- Addressing economic and social causes by reducing poverty and inequality, and improving access to education and healthcare services.

- Building a culture of peace and social dialogue by promoting communication among different groups and fostering tolerance and acceptance of diversity.

The chapter links structural causes and social, political, and economic factors to practical strategies, offering a comprehensive vision for reducing political violence and enhancing stability and sustainable development.

Section 1: Social and Political Effects of Political Violence:

Political violence is a complex phenomenon that affects both society and the state on social and political levels, these effects can be analyzed across several main dimensions:

1-Social Effects :

The effects of political violence extend beyond immediate acts, impacting the social fabric of

the entire community by influencing relationships between individuals and groups and weakening core societal bonds, political violence not only threatens the physical security of individuals but also creates an environment of mistrust, fear, and division, affecting the cohesion and stability of society in the long term, therefore, analyzing these social effects is an essential step in understanding the depth of the crisis and identifying ways to strengthen social cohesion and prevent the recurrence of violence.

- Destruction of the Social Fabric:

Political violence undermines trust among individuals and groups within society and exacerbates class, ethnic, and religious divisions, Gurr notes that violent conflicts weaken social bonds and the capacity for collective cooperation, creating an environment of instability and tension among different social groups (Gurr, 2015, p. 34).

- Forced Displacement and Refugee Crises :

Political conflict often forces populations to flee their regions, generating refugee and internal displacement crises that affect demographic structures and increase economic and social pressures on host communities, Kaldor highlights that forced displacement reflects the impact of political violence on everyday life and increases the fragility of social cohesion (Kaldor, 2013, p. 56).

- Impact on Education and Health :

Educational and healthcare institutions in conflict areas often face destruction or disruption of services, leading to a decline in the quality of education and public health services, Justino notes that such conditions increase poverty and social deprivation, particularly among vulnerable groups, making society more prone to cycles of violence and conflict (Justino, 2012, p. 79).

2- Political Effects :

Political violence profoundly impacts the functioning and stability of political institutions and the overall governance of the state, it undermines public trust in leadership, weakens institutional legitimacy, and disrupts democratic processes, creating a cycle of instability and polarization, these political effects is essential to designing effective strategies that strengthen governance, protect democratic mechanisms, and prevent the recurrence of violence.

- Weakening Political Legitimacy:

Political violence directly affects the legitimacy of the state and political institutions, reducing citizens' confidence in their ability to manage conflicts and protect rights. Weber emphasizes that the state relies on a monopoly of legitimate violence, and when force is used to suppress society rather than regulate it, state legitimacy erodes and counter-violence escalates, creating a vicious cycle of political and social decline (Weber, 2012, p. 56).

- Disruption of Democratic and Institutional Processes :

Political violence disrupts democratic processes, such as elections, parliamentary operations, and institutional oversight mechanisms, Tilly points out that this leads to an unstable political environment, limiting the ability of political actors to achieve peaceful conflict resolution and opening the door to increased reciprocal violence and power struggles (Tilly, 2003, p. 7).

- Escalation of Political Polarization and Divisions :

Political violence contributes to increased polarization among political groups, creating an atmosphere of hostility and fear, which hinders dialogue and peaceful conflict

resolution. Gurr notes that ongoing violence reinforces a culture of revenge and reciprocal violence, increasing the likelihood of future conflicts between different groups within the state (Gurr, 2015, p. 42).

It is evident that political violence has deep and multifaceted effects on both society and the state. It leads to destruction of the social fabric, forced displacement, and deterioration of basic services such as education and health, which weakens social cohesion. Politically, it undermines state legitimacy, disrupts democratic processes, and intensifies political polarization, complicating conflict management and threatening state stability.

Consequently, political violence is not only a direct threat to security and peace but also reproduces social and political crises, making it essential to address its economic, social, and political roots to maintain stability and achieve sustainable development.

Section 2: Impacts of Political Violence on Stability and Development:

Political violence constitutes a major factor hindering political and social stability and affecting the trajectories of economic and social development in affected societies. Its impacts can be analyzed through several main dimensions:

1-Impacts on Political Stability :

Political violence significantly threatens the stability of a state by weakening institutions, increasing polarization, and undermining citizens' trust in governance, when violence disrupts the normal functioning of political systems, it creates an environment of uncertainty and insecurity, making it harder for governments to manage conflicts peacefully, understanding these impacts is crucial for developing strategies that strengthen political stability, maintain order, and prevent cycles of recurring violence.

- Fragility of Political Institutions:

Political violence weakens governmental institutions and democratic practices, reducing their ability to enforce the law and protect citizens' fundamental rights, Tilly notes that this fragility renders the state more vulnerable to escalating conflicts and worsening political crises, as violence becomes an alternative means for actors to access power or influence decisions, reflecting the fragility of the political structure of the state (Tilly, 2003, p. 7).

-Increased Polarization and Internal Conflict :

Political violence contributes to rising political and social divisions among different groups and intensifies polarization among political actors, according to Gurr, the persistence of violence hinders political dialogue and peaceful conflict resolution, entrenching a culture of conflict and hostility among groups (Gurr, 2015, p. 42).

- Erosion of Trust in the State and Leadership:

Continued violence erodes citizens' trust in the state and weakens government legitimacy, Weber emphasizes that the state's monopoly on legitimate violence is threatened when force is used to suppress society, prompting individuals and groups to resort to illegal means to achieve their demands, thereby perpetuating cycles of political violence (Weber, 2012, p. 56).

2-Impacts on Economic and Social Development :

Political violence has profound effects on economic growth and social progress. It disrupts investment, damages infrastructure, and limits access to essential services such as education and healthcare, These disruptions weaken human capital, increase poverty, and reduce opportunities for development, creating a cycle of socio-economic vulnerability,

analyzing these impacts is essential for designing policies that promote sustainable development and resilience in societies affected by political conflicts.

-Decline in Investments and Local Economy :

Political violence halts economic projects, reduces domestic and foreign investment, and increases production costs, weakening the economy and raising poverty and unemployment rates, studies show that ongoing conflicts reduce opportunities for economic growth and limit the state's ability to provide jobs and improve living standards, this effect is particularly evident in countries experiencing prolonged conflicts, where violence impacts all sectors of the economy and constrains sustainable development (Collier & Hoeffler, 2004, p. 563).

- Destruction of Infrastructure and Public Services :

Basic infrastructure—such as roads, hospitals, and schools—suffers damage or neglect due to armed conflicts and political violence, hindering development and affecting the daily quality of life for residents, Justino notes that such damage exacerbates poverty and social deprivation and limits communities' capacity to recover from crises, reinforcing cycles of violence and persistent social fragility (Justino, 2012, p. 79).

- Impact on Human Capital :

Political violence disrupts education, prompts brain drain, and causes setbacks in public health, limiting the development of human capital essential for sustainable development, Kaldor emphasizes that prolonged conflicts reduce the state's ability to invest in human resources, delay long-term economic and social development, deepen social gaps, and increase the likelihood of future crises (Kaldor, 2013, p. 56).

It is evident from the analysis that political violence has deep negative effects on political stability and economic and social development; It leads to institutional fragility, increased polarization, and erosion of trust in the state and leadership, limiting governments' capacity to manage conflicts effectively. Economically and socially, it reduces investment, destroys infrastructure, and undermines human capital, increasing poverty and unemployment while obstructing sustainable development.

Thus, political violence is not merely a security issue—it is a central factor undermining state stability and societal progress at both economic and social levels.

Section 3: Mechanisms to Reduce Political Violence:

Reducing political violence is an essential necessity for maintaining social and political stability and promoting sustainable development, mechanisms to mitigate political violence can be approached through three main dimensions:

1-Strengthening Political Institutions and Democracy :

Enhancing political institutions and democratic governance is a fundamental strategy for reducing political violence, strong, transparent, and accountable institutions increase public trust, ensure the fair resolution of disputes, and provide legitimate channels for political participation, by promoting inclusive decision-making and protecting citizens' rights, robust political institutions help prevent conflicts from escalating into violence and contribute to long-term stability and social cohesion.

- Enhancing Legitimacy and Transparency:

Building strong and transparent political institutions is one of the most important

mechanisms to reduce political violence, as it reduces citizens' frustration and reinforces their trust in the state. Studies indicate that institutions capable of managing conflicts peacefully and enforcing laws fairly diminish the tendency to resort to violence as a means of resolving political and social disputes (Tilly, 2003, p. 12), this underscores the importance of institutions that can regulate political life and establish clear rules for conflict resolution.

- Expanding Political Participation :

Expanding opportunities for participation in political processes—such as free and fair elections, and creating channels for dialogue among political actors—is an effective way to reduce feelings of political and social exclusion, Gurr emphasizes that providing legitimate avenues for participation allows conflicts to be resolved peacefully and reduces the inclination to resort to violence to achieve demands, thereby enhancing political stability and strengthening societal legitimacy of the state (Gurr, 2015, p. 44).

2- Addressing Economic and Social Causes :

Tackling the economic and social roots of political violence is essential for creating a stable and peaceful society, reducing poverty, inequality, and unemployment, as well as improving access to education, healthcare, and basic services, helps to decrease social frustration and marginalization, by addressing these structural challenges, governments and communities can prevent grievances from turning into violent actions, foster social cohesion, and promote sustainable development.

- Reducing Poverty and Inequality:

Poverty and economic and social inequality create fertile ground for political violence, as

they increase frustration among marginalized groups and heighten feelings of exclusion, studies show that policies focused on redistributing economic resources, providing equal opportunities for marginalized groups, and improving access to basic services reduce the likelihood of conflict, as they narrow the gap between expectations and reality and address sources of social tension (Collier & Hoeffler, 2004, p. 570).

- Enhancing Education and Health :

Improving access to education and healthcare builds human capital and reduces social vulnerability, thereby alleviating violence stemming from social frustration and lack of opportunities, Justino notes that investment in education and health not only improves individuals' economic capacities but also enhances social and political awareness, reducing the likelihood of youth and marginalized groups engaging in violent activities (Justino, 2012, p. 81).

3-Building a Culture of Peace and Social Dialogue :

Promoting a culture of peace and encouraging social dialogue are essential strategies to prevent political violence, by fostering communication, negotiation, and mutual understanding among conflicting groups, societies can manage disputes peacefully and reduce tensions. Raising awareness about human rights, tolerance, and acceptance of diversity helps build social cohesion and trust, creating an environment where conflicts are resolved through dialogue rather than force, this approach not only mitigates immediate tensions but also strengthens long-term stability and democratic governance.

- Dialogue and Negotiation among Different Parties:

Encouraging dialogue and negotiation between conflicting groups and civil society is one of

the most effective mechanisms for reducing political violence, as it allows parties to express their interests and concerns peacefully, Kaldor emphasizes that involving civil society in conflict management and using civil arbitration reduces the likelihood of escalating violence, promotes a culture of negotiated solutions instead of violent ones, and enhances trust among disputing parties (Kaldor, 2013, p. 60).

- Community Awareness and Promoting Tolerance :

Raising awareness of human rights, encouraging tolerance, and accepting social and political differences is an effective way to reduce social and political friction. Galtung notes that building a culture of peace based on dialogue and understanding helps break cycles of continuous violence, strengthens social and political stability, and reduces the tendency toward revenge or the use of force to achieve interests (Galtung, 1969, p. 173).

Effective strategies to reduce political violence focus on three integrated pillars: strengthening political institutions and democracy, addressing economic and social causes, and building a culture of peace and social dialogue, by enhancing legitimacy, expanding political participation, reducing poverty and inequality, improving education and health, and promoting community dialogue, the root causes of violence can be mitigated, preventing its escalation, these mechanisms demonstrate that reducing political violence requires a multi-dimensional approach encompassing politics, economy, and society, with a strong emphasis on tolerance and dialogue as foundations for lasting stability and sustainable development.

The chapter concludes that successfully reducing political violence relies on the combination of political, economic, and social reforms, alongside strengthening democratic

institutions, fostering social participation, and promoting tolerance and dialogue, this comprehensive approach mitigates the causes of violence, lowers its risks to society and the state, and establishes a solid foundation for addressing future conflicts peacefully.

Conclusion:

After an in-depth study, the research concluded that political violence is a multidimensional phenomenon influenced by interrelated social, political, and economic factors; it cannot be fully explained or addressed from a single perspective.

-Findings :

The study revealed that:

-Social and economic causes, such as class inequality, poverty, unemployment, and ethnic and religious divisions, provide a fertile ground for the emergence of political violence.

-Political causes, including weak institutions, power struggles, and repressive policies, increase the likelihood of escalating conflicts.

-Political violence leads to institutional fragility, loss of trust in leadership, disruption of democratic processes, destruction of infrastructure, and erosion of human capital, all of which negatively affect development and stability.

-Mechanisms to reduce political violence require a multidimensional approach encompassing the strengthening of institutions and democracy, addressing poverty and inequality, and fostering a culture of dialogue and tolerance.

-Recommendations :

Based on the findings, the following recommendations can be proposed:

-Strengthen democratic and transparent institutions to ensure peaceful conflict management and enhance citizens' trust in the state.

-Develop economic and social policies that reduce poverty and inequality while providing opportunities for marginalized groups.

-Promote education and awareness of human rights and political culture to foster tolerance and acceptance of differences.

-Activate the role of civil society and community dialogue in conflict resolution, creating a stable and safe environment.

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